state in question. The immediate neighbours' own neighbours, in turn, are likely to be potential allies to the protagonist state since they are subject to the same dynamic with respect to their own immediate neighbours. But these categories are not immutable and can change depending on the circumstances.

The 'instruments' to be used in handling situations involving neighbouring states are the same as in the *Arthashastra* : *sama* (conciliation or alliance), *dana* (placating and winning over with gifts), *danda* (punishing through the use of force) and *bheda* (sowing dissension). The *Nitisara* clearly lays down that *danda* – the use of coercive power or war – is the last resort after all other options have failed. The tradition also attaches higher value to wise counsel (*mantra-shakti*) than to the power of the king based on his treasury, his army (*prabhava)* or his own energetic temperament (*utsaha-shakti*). It enjoins the ruler to make a clear determination between what is attainable and what is not through cool and intelligent deliberation, that is, through the application of *mantra-shakti* . [5]

Kamandaki devotes a separate chapter to the role of diplomats and diplomacy titled 'Dutapracana'. [6] This is an ancient Indian version of British diplomat Ernest Satow's *A Guide to Diplomatic Practice* first published in 1917. Satow's book, regarded as a classic, was our bible when I joined the Indian Foreign Service in 1970. At that time, unfortunately, neither my colleagues nor I knew anything about India's own fascinating and still very relevant contribution to the theory and practice of diplomacy. We only turned to British sources.

Kamandaki lists three categories of royal ambassadors: the first is empowered by the king to take decisions while on a mission, something like a plenipotentiary these days; the second has limited and specific powers, perhaps like the ranking diplomat of today who is assigned specific representational responsibilities; and the third has the role of an envoy who is only an emissary with the task of delivering and receiving messages on behalf of his king. The *Nitisara* goes into considerable detail about the qualities of a royal ambassador and the manner in which he should conduct himself while on a mission. The following quotes give a flavour of